

15 Trips We Love

PLAN NOW FOR YOUR NEXT ADVENTURE, WHETHER YOU WANT TO SPIN EASY AND SEE THE SIGHTS OR RIDE YOUR BUTT OFF—OR BOTH.

BY MEGHAN LOFTUS

*** Live the Cross-Country Dream**
CROSS COUNTRY USA, TREK TRAVEL
 If you're ready to go big, Trek Travel will take you on a one-of-a-kind wild trip: A fully supported 3,178-mile ride across the United States—in 40 days (four rest days). It starts in Santa Barbara, California, and ends in Charleston, South Carolina. **2009 DATES:** September 13–October 22 **MILES PER DAY:** 81 **COST:** \$14,500–\$16,500 (The more people who register, the less the trip costs.) **INFO:** trektravel.com

Follow the Tour de France
LANCE IN FRANCE, VELO ECHAPPE
 Specializing in tours of France, this company has been guiding trips for more than a decade, and its Tour staff has worked together for nine years. Guides are American and French cyclists. **2009 DATES:** Weekend and weeklong trips throughout the Tour de France in July **MILES PER DAY:** 30–60 **COST:** \$1,199–\$5,599 **INFO:** veloechappe.com

Taste the Best of California
NAPA & SONOMA COUNTIES: VINEYARDS, REDWOODS & COAST, BACKROADS
 Backroads has been offering this six-day trip since the 1980s and says that, like a fine wine, it keeps getting better with age. Currently, it's a rich blend of winery stops and spa treatments. Those pressed for time can opt for a shorter weekend tour. **2009 DATES:** Several from spring through fall **MILES PER DAY:** 25 (short routes), 45 (long routes) **COST:** \$2,098–

\$2,898 (depending on occupancy and inn level selected) **INFO:** backroads.com

Get Away with the Girls
MOAB TOUR, WOMANTOURS
 Moab's best-kept secret is that it also has amazing road riding. In addition to pedaling through Arches and Canyonlands National Parks, this road tour also makes time for hiking and rafting. **2009 DATES:** October 11–17 **MILES PER DAY:** 32 (short route), 68 (long route) **COST:** \$1,790 **INFO:** womantours.com

Pedal through American History
C&O CANAL BICYCLE TOUR, BIKE AND THE LIKE
 Meander along the Potomac River Valley and along the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal, with stops at Fort Frederick, the Antietam Battlefield and other historic places. This company keeps costs low and the pace mellow, so the whole family can enjoy the ride. **2009 DATES:** October 11–16 **MILES PER DAY:** 33 **COST:** \$750 **INFO:** bikeandthelike.com

*** Extend Beach Season**
SUNNY SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA SINGLETRACK TOUR, HERMOSA TOURS
 What could be better during the shoulder seasons, when it's chilly in most of the United States, than five days of warm dirt? During the second half of this trip, for intermediate riders and up, you'll stay in ocean-side accommodations. **2009 DATES:** Several in early spring and late fall **MILES PER DAY:** 18 **COST:** \$1,950 **INFO:** hermosatours.net

Go Euro—Without Leaving North America
QUEBEC BIKING, BUTTERFIELD & ROBINSON
 Start in Montreal and end in historic Quebec City—culturally, you'll feel like you're in luxurious France the entire way. In our experience, Butterfield's services and accommodations are four star. **2009 DATES:** July 12–17, August 9–14, September 6–11 **MILES PER DAY:** 22–30 **COST:** \$5,695 **INFO:** butterfield.com

Wear Out Your Passport
LAKE CONSTANCE TO ALSACE, AUSTIN LEHMAN ADVENTURES
 In nine days, you'll visit three countries: Germany, Switzerland and France. One day's route crosses a border five times. **2009 DATES:** June 6–14, July 18–26, August 15–23, September 12–20 **MILES PER DAY:** 21 (short route), 33 (long route) **COST:** \$3,998 (comfort); \$4,998 (luxury) **INFO:** austinlehman.com

*** Climb the Giro d'Italia Mountains**
LEGENDARY CLIMBS OF THE GIRO D'ITALIA, CYCLEITALIA
 Tackle all the classics: the Passo Stelvio, Mortirolo and the historic climb to Madonna di Ghisallo, among others. It helps to be fit enough to climb like a mountain goat, but CycleItalia's support van will also be on hand to help. **2009 DATES:** June 27–July 8 **MILES PER DAY:** 60 **COST:** \$4,895 **INFO:** cycleitalia.com

Prove Your Purist Bona Fides
EROICA TOUR, CINGHIALE CYCLING TOURS
 Spend a week in Tuscany with '88 Giro winner Andy Hampsten, pedaling through Chianti and hearing old war stories. Then cap it off with L'Eroica, a retro century (with a category for participants on bikes built pre-1980) that covers both paved and dirt roads. **2009 DATES:** September 29–October 6 **MILES PER DAY:** 30–70 **COST:** About \$4,000 **INFO:** cinghiale.com

Soak Up the Foliage Season
CHAMPLAIN VALLEY & ISLANDS, VERMONT BICYCLE TOURS
 Red barns: check. White steeples: check. Quaint New England villages: check. Spectacular fall foliage: check. Also included in this six-day trip are a visit to

Shelburne Museum and a trip to Lake Champlain. **2009 DATES:** Several from May through October **MILES PER DAY:** 23 **COST:** \$1,545–\$2,045 (higher cost is during peak foliage season) **INFO:** vbt.com

Do It the Hard Way, Sort Of
RED ROCK RAMBLE, ADVENTURE CYCLING ASSOCIATION
 Riders carry their own gear on this weeklong tour through scenic southern Utah, but they eat three prepared meals each day and sleep in beds each night. **2009 DATES:** May 30–June 5 **MILES PER DAY:** 50 **COST:** \$1,599 **INFO:** adventurecycling.org

Explore Ancient Ruins
SACRED SITES, CYCLE GREECE
 Ride to Olympia, where the Games began, and Mycenae, home of Trojan War leader King Agamemnon, among other ancient sites. One of the guides is a professor at West Point who specializes in Greek military history. **2009 DATES:** May 12–23, August 26–September 6 **MILES PER DAY:** 32 (short route), 47 (long route) **COST:** 3,660€ (about \$5,180) **INFO:** cyclegreece.gr

*** Ride with the Whole Family**
GRAND CANYON SOUTH RIM FAMILY TRIP, WESTERN SPIRIT
 Introduce your kids to mountain biking on this five-day trip. The singletrack trails are flat and nontechnical, the daily distance never exceeds 26 miles, and a support van is always present in case kids (or grown-ups) want to take a break and just hang out. **2009 DATES:** Several in June or early July **COST:** \$1,185 (\$1,085 under age 14) **INFO:** westernspirit.com

Make a Complete Breakaway
GRAND TOUR AND SOUTHERN SCENIC TOUR, PEDALTOURS
 While this New Zealand-based company offers shorter tours, the 23-day combo trip has you pedaling the entire length of New Zealand's South Island. **2009 DATES:** January 4–26, February 25–March 19 **MILES PER DAY:** 53 (Grand Tour); 57 (Southern Scenic Tour) **COST:** \$8,475 New Zealand (about \$5,660) **INFO:** pedaltours.co.nz

*** About 85 miles into the 115-mile ride between Tuba City, Arizona, and Mexican Hat, Utah**



*** Descending the San Juan Trail during the grand finale ride**

*** A view from the top of Italy's Passo Sella**



*** A scenic ride above the Canyon on the tour's last day**